facilities in the middle of the night. Everyone had already walked 25 kilometres that day, and it was simply not fair to tell them to go stay in motels nearby (in any case, the parts of Maharashtra we were walking through barely had guesthouses, let alone motels and hotels). Hundreds of mattresses and mobile toilets had to be trucked in within an hour from another district. Meanwhile, we had to handle a massive, ever-growing crowd patiently and sensitively. I had five volunteers, and quickly realized I would need more Congress volunteers to help out. It was all hands on deck! The second problem was issuing passes to so many yatris and registering them on the spot (this was our only way to cross-check that no unwanted intruders were entering the Yatra). We were issuing passes like ticket conductors to hundreds of yatris, then ensuring they were fed and making sure each person got a mattress and blanket. That evening, although I hadn't walked the Yatra because I was busy with these arrangements, my pedometer clocked 30,000 steps! My team was running around even more than me, so I shudder to think of the state of their feet that evening. We finally managed to get everything settled sometime around midnight, which is when we had to make do with a modest meal of plain rice and besan (gram lentil).

But there was absolutely no rest because we had to wake up at 4 a.m. to ensure the mobile bathrooms (which were nothing more than three plastic walls and a curtain) were functioning. This was no mean feat, given temperatures were dipping below ten degrees. When that was sorted, we had to wake up the yatris, who had to get ready, have breakfast and then be ready to join the Yatra at 5.45 a.m. It was physically impossible to wake up everyone individually, so I had to resort to our tried-and-tested jugaad (innovation). I commandeered the audio and stereo systems, and started playing patriotic songs (like a nationalist disc jockey). Between each song, I was making announcements. '*Yatriyon, kripiya uth jaiye. Jaldi se snan aur bhojan kar lijiye. Rasta ruka hain* (Yatris, please wake up. Quickly bathe and have food. The road awaits us).' Although I didn't intend it to be so, many yatris woke up both bewildered and laughing, saying they imagined they had been magically transported to a railway station!